DOE ASPECT · DE-FOA-0003647 · TOPIC AREA 1, SUBTOPIC 1a

Ten steps to a submitted concept paper

Steps 1 through 4 are checks that have to happen before the upload and cannot be done from this container. Steps 5 through 10 are the submission itself.

Oct 9, 5:00 PM ET	About 40 minutes	None stated
DEADLINE	TIME REQUIRED	SIGNATURES AT THIS STAGE

DOE advises submitting one to two days before the deadline. Any change made after the submit button is pressed unsubmits the application and it must be resubmitted.

CHECKS BEFORE UPLOAD

Do these first

1. **Log in to DOE eXCHANGE** at eere-exchange.energy.gov and confirm the PlastiBioFuel LLC account works. The system returned from its consolidation outage on 2026-10-04 at 6:00 AM ET. If the account does not exist, create it now rather than on the ninth; portal support is EERE-ExchangeSupport@hq.doe.gov with the NOFO title and DE-FOA-0003647 in the subject line.

2. **Download NOFO Part 1 and the concept paper template** from the Documents section of announcement DE-FOA-0003647. Both are Word files. This container is blocked from retrieving them, which is why steps 2 through 4 are yours rather than the package's.

3. **Appendix A is settled; spot-check it and read the Q and A log.** Appendix A was read in full on 2026-10-09 at pages 58 and 59 of NOFO Part 1 Modification 000002. Sorted municipal solid waste is marked acceptable and defined as the organic and plastic constituents of the municipal solid waste stream going to the landfill, which is why this concept paper names that category rather than post-consumer PET on its own. The table is exclusive: a feedstock it does not identify will not be considered. Spot-check those two pages, then open the DE-FOA-0003647 Question and Answer Log, last updated 2026-09-24 at 4:51 PM ET.

4. **Check this concept paper against the template's field list** in NOFO Part 1 section 4.C. The document is written to DOE's four published evaluation factors, which is the right content, but the template may want it in a different order or under different headings. Reorder rather than rewrite.

THE SUBMISSION

About 40 minutes

5. Find DE-FOA-0003647 in eXCHANGE and click Apply. Enter the project title: Bench-Scale Process Development for Enzymatic Production of Terephthalic Acid from Post-Consumer PET.

6. Select **Topic Area 1, Subtopic Area 1a**. One topic area and one concept only. Subtopic 1a is the entry point for technology that is past proof of concept and needs bench-scale development; it is also the only Topic Area 1 subtopic that does not exclude work on heterogeneous or powder-form catalysis, which matters for a framework-immobilized enzyme.

7. Upload **02_Concept_Paper.pdf**. Confirm in the reader that it is five pages or fewer before uploading. Anything past page five is not reviewed and may disqualify the concept paper.

8. Complete every required field, then click Submit. Do it on 2026-10-07 or 2026-10-08, not on the ninth. The APPLY and SUBMIT buttons disable automatically at 5:00 PM ET on 2026-10-09 and DOE enforces that as a hard deadline.

9. Confirm receipt in eXCHANGE and keep the confirmation. If a technical problem causes a late submission, DOE accepts it only when you encountered difficulties beyond your control, contacted the helpdesk at exchangehelp@hq.doe.gov, and submitted within 24 hours of the posted deadline. All three conditions, not any one of them.

10. Record the submission date in FUNDING_REGISTRY.md and correct the ASPECT row, which still reads Package built. Also submit the teaming entry for TPL-0000073 if that has not been done, and record the date.

WHERE MICHAEL SIGNS

Nowhere at the concept paper stage, as far as any DOE source read for this package states. No certification or signature block is described for the concept paper, and the exact field list in NOFO Part 1 section 4.C has not been read, so confirm when the template is open.

The first signatures fall at Stage 1 on 2026-12-01: the cost share commitment, the Research, Technology and Economic Security materials, and whatever certifications the Stage 1 content requirements carry. An industrial partner, not Michael, signs the Letter of Commitment at Stage 1.

WHAT SUBMITTING DOES AND DOES NOT COMMIT

THE CONCEPT PAPER IS NOT BINDING

> DOE, in the published webinar transcript: applicants are not obligated to apply after submitting a concept paper, are not bound to the statements made in it, and it is reasonable for project partners, locations, and other factors to change during application development. What the concept paper does buy is eligibility: Stage 1 is open only to applicants whose concept paper DOE reviewed and found eligible, and DOE will not review a Stage 1 application from anyone it did not invite.

DATES TO HOLD

2026-10-09, 5:00 PM ET	Concept paper closes. Hard deadline, buttons disable automatically.
2026-12-01, 5:00 PM ET	Stage 1 application. Letter of commitment and cost share documentation fall here.
mid-January 2027	Stage 2 invitations. An invitee-only webinar is expected on or around 2027-01-20.
2027-02-12	Stage 2 application due. DOE advises staffing for engagement between roughly 2027-01-10 and mid-February.
mid-April 2027	Selection notifications and the start of award negotiation.

Program questions: ASPECT@doe.gov · Portal support: EERE-ExchangeSupport@hq.doe.gov · michael@plastibiofuel.com

Verified October 5, 2026